

Weight Suppression & Hormones

How Do Eating Disorders Affect Hormones?

Eating habits and weight play an important role in our hormone levels. Disordered eating, compensatory behaviours (e.g. excessive exercise), and body weight can disrupt hormone production. Hormones that regulate metabolism, fertility, pregnancy, and bone health are particularly affected by disordered eating.

Fertility in Females and Males

When the body is not receiving enough food, it reduces processes that require a lot of energy, including functions of the reproductive system. Low levels of the hormones oestrogen, progesterone, and testosterone can lead to reduced fertility or infertility in people experiencing an eating disorder.

In women, symptoms may include:

- Low libido (reduced sexual desire)
- Absence of menstrual periods
- Irregular menstrual periods



In men, symptoms may include:

- Low libido (sexual desire);
- Loss of early morning erections;
- Loss of nocturnal emissions ("wet dreams").

Hormonal changes associated with eating disorders are usually reversible. With consistent nourishment and a return to a body weight that is healthy for you, sexual desire and physical functioning typically improve over time.

Importantly, even if you are experiencing signs of reduced fertility, it is still important to use contraception if you are sexually active and do not wish to become pregnant. Fertility can return unexpectedly, and pregnancy can occur even before any obvious signs of reproductive changes appear.

Pregnancy

Eating disorders can affect reproductive hormones and overall health during pregnancy. People who become pregnant while their body is not receiving adequate or consistent nutrition may have a higher risk of pregnancy-related complications. These can

include high blood pressure, gestational diabetes, anaemia, and an increased chance of miscarriage or a more complex delivery.

There may also be risks for the developing baby, such as premature birth, low or high birth weight, feeding difficulties, or breathing problems after birth. Most people who have recovered from an eating disorder can go on to have healthy pregnancies and healthy babies.



Bone Health & Osteoporosis

Eating disorders can have a significant impact on bone health. When the body is not receiving enough consistent nutrition, bones can lose strength and become more fragile. This can lead to osteoporosis, a condition where bones become brittle, and break more easily.

When the body does not have adequate energy or nutrient reserves, several hormones are affected. These include sex hormones (such as oestrogen and testosterone), as well as cortisol, IGF-I (insulin-like growth factor), and leptin. Changes in these hormones can slow bone growth and may lead to bone loss over time.

Although existing bone loss cannot be fully reversed, further damage can often be prevented. Restoring adequate nutrition, and supporting the body back to its natural healthy weight range are key steps in protecting bone health.

Other Hormonal Effects

- Low levels of thyroid hormones may cause constipation and dry skin;
- High levels of stress hormones (e.g., cortisol, noradrenaline) can cause sleep problems, anxiety, depression, or panic (e.g. increased heart rate)
- Eating disorders may also impact on hormones involved in appetite, puberty and growth.

Seeking Help

For further guidance please speak to a medical practitioner.